parliament. It also leads to certain areas of the country being over- or under-represented: only seven lawmakers (6 per cent) hail from the southern periphery, which has 1.2 million residents (15 per cent of the population). A system of single-member districts might be too parochial for a small country, and it would create a number of permanently uncompetitive constituencies in ultra-Orthodox and Arab areas. But multiple-member districts could help to reduce the clout of small, sectoral parties.

Ha'aretz periodically floats a plan to go much further and divide Israel into cantons, an idea modeled on Switzerland, of all places. The Swiss confederation was created to avoid conflict between various ethnic and religious groups. On the surface, at least, this principle seems applicable to Israel, populated by groups with deeply incompatible visions of what it means to be an Israeli or a Jew.

"Imagine if in one Israeli province, you could get legally married under a rainbow chuppah, shop till you drop on Saturdays, not to mention visit any number of licensed cannabis cafes? Horrified at the thought? Then try neighboring 'Judah province', where cars on Shabbat, pork-serving eateries and flesh-revealing billboards could all be outlawed," the newspaper mused in 2014.[13]

One can see the appeal of this idea, particularly for the sorts of people who read *Ha'aretz*. But tens of thousands of secular Israelis live in Jerusalem, along with 300,000 Palestinians. A hypothetical coastal province south of Tel Aviv would include right-wing Likud supporters, ultra-Orthodox residents of Ashdod, *kibbutzniks*, and young families priced out of the commercial capital. The geographic divisions in Israel do not lend themselves readily to such a decentralized system. And yet, as the forthcoming election would demonstrate, the idea has a grain of merit: how can the Israeli political system possibly represent millions of people with fundamentally incompatible visions of what it means to live together?